

shown consistency, while also assessing the fitness levels of Rohit and Kohli to gain clarity on whether they remain in the plans for the marquee event.

Not quite easy

The scheduling, however, leaves much to be desired. Teams that featured in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy Super League will have little turnaround time, needing to switch formats within a couple of days. That will pose a significant challenge.

"It would have been better if we had got three or four more days before starting the Vijay Hazare Trophy, because we didn't get rest even after the Ranji Trophy first leg, so a small break here would have helped. But the BCCI has already decided on the dates," says Jharkhand top-order batter Kumar Kushagra.

The workload challenge is even greater for fast bowlers. For players like Siraj and Arshdeep Singh, who have played almost continuously, managing workload will be key. In the previous edition, Arshdeep finished as the leading wicket-taker with 20 scalps, followed by Varun Chakaravathy and Vasuki Koushik, who each claimed 18 wickets.

India international and Haryana pacer Anshul Kamboj believes that, given the packed calendar, staying in the present is crucial. "It is challenging for sure, but if you think too much about it, it only complicates things and puts pressure," he says.

Favourite no more?

Defending champion Karnataka, which won six of its seven group league fixtures last season, finds itself in a particularly demanding group alongside Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Jharkhand and Pondicherry. Karnataka will pin its hopes on Karun Nair, the highest run-scorer in the previous edition (779), albeit for his

former team Vidarbha, and captain Mayank Agarwal. Neither Karun nor Mayank had a memorable outing in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, and both will be keen to rediscover form when their campaign begins in Ahmedabad.

Group B also promises intrigue, featuring Bengal, Hyderabad, last year's runner-up Vidarbha and Jammu and Kashmir. While attention will be on Bengal's seasoned campaigner Mohammed Shami, who has been out of national reckoning since the Champions Trophy, Jammu and Kashmir, buoyed by its recent Ranji Trophy success, will also fancy its chances. With Aquib Nabi spearheading the fast-bowling unit, J&K will hope to make an impact in Rajkot.

Group C comprises Mumbai, Maharashtra and Punjab. With Ayush Mhatre, among the top scorers last season, likely to return for Mumbai, the domestic heavyweight appears to be placed in a relatively comfortable group that also includes Sikkim, Uttarakhand and Chandigarh.

In Bengaluru, Kohli headlines Group D, with Delhi grouped alongside Haryana, Saurashtra, Andhra and Services. While some high-octane contests are on the cards, Delhi, which struggled in both the Ranji Trophy and the Syed

Mushtaq Ali Trophy, will need to address key shortcomings to progress. As Rajasthan coach Anshu Jain points out, white-ball cricket offers little margin for error. "One good spell or one good innings can change the game, so there's a level-playing field," he says.

Pitch woes

Despite the BCCI instructing State units to prepare livelier wickets to move away from spin-heavy surfaces, conditions remain largely unchanged. During the first phase of the Ranji Trophy, most pitches were flat, forcing bowlers to toil. With little time between tournaments, curators have limited room for adjustment. While most centres are likely to witness run-heavy contests, the three venues in Jaipur could assist fast bowlers early, especially as temperatures dip.



Gradual reintegration: Rishabh Pant re-entered the ODI picture in the home series against South Africa, serving as the second wicketkeeper to K. L. Rahul after an absence that stretched back to August 2024. K. R. DEEPAK